

interviews

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Small Talk

Small talk is a short informal conversation at the beginning of a meeting to break the ice, make people feel relaxed and set a positive atmosphere. It's common practice for interviewers to start the interview with small talk.

Key Rules

1. **Be engaged!** The interviewer might make small talk with a question about your day ("How are you doing today?") or a short comment about the weather. Speak in a friendly manner and make sure your replies are not too short.
2. **Ask back!** Your conversation should not be one-sided. Remember: it's a talk, and each talk requires minimum two sides. You need to react, share experiences, demonstrate interest and ask follow-up questions. If the interviewer asks a "How are you" question, give an answer about your day and ask about the interviewer's day.
3. **It's small talk, not big talk!** Don't tell the interviewer the story of your life. Small talk is normally not longer than a couple of minutes.

Small Talk Example: What NOT to Do

Interviewer: Hi Alex, can you hear me fine?

Candidate: Yes.

Interviewer: Great! Glad to meet you, my name's Elon and I'm the tech lead manager of Xsoft.

Candidate: Hi, Elon.

Interviewer: So, Alex, how has your day been so far?

Candidate: I don't have any news.

Interviewer: Well, what's the weather like in your location? It's awful here in London if you ask me.

Candidate: It's bad.

Interviewer: Erm... Let's get started then. Are you ready?

Candidate: Yes.

What went wrong: One-word answers, no follow-up questions, no engagement, no personality.

Small Talk Example: Good Version

Interviewer: Hi Alex, can you hear me fine?

Candidate: Yeah, I hear you pretty well, and do you hear me?

Interviewer: Absolutely! Well, glad to meet you, my name's Elon and I'm the tech lead manager of Xsoft.

Candidate: Hello Elon. Nice to meet you, too!

Interviewer: So, Alex, how has your day been so far?

Candidate: So far so good. I've been rather busy lately. And how is your day going?

Interviewer: Going good, thank you! Well, what's the weather like in your location? It's awful here in London if you ask me.

Candidate: You know, the same story here in Yerevan - it's been raining all day really.

Interviewer: Oh, sorry to hear that... Well, let's get started then? Are you ready?

Candidate: Sure! Let's kick it off.

What went right: Full answers, asks back, shows warmth, shares something personal, shows enthusiasm.

Safe Topics

- Day / Weather
- Holiday and weekend plans
- Recent positive news

Small Talk Situations

Situations and Phrases

Situation	Phrases
You're happy	It's going great!
You're feeling okay	Not bad, thanks.
You're busy	I've been really busy.
You're tired	I'm a bit tired.
You're excited	I'm looking forward to the weekend.
You're meeting someone new	Nice to meet you.
You're greeting someone	How's it going? How have you been?
You're leaving	Have a good day!
You're asking about someone's plans	Do you have any plans for the weekend?
You're starting a conversation about the weather	Nice weather, isn't it?
You're complimenting someone	That's a nice shirt/dress/tie. Where did you get it?
You're ending a conversation	It was nice talking to you.
You're suggesting something	Would you like to grab a coffee?
You're asking about opinions	What do you think about...?
You're talking about sports	Did you watch the game last night?
You're talking about movies	Have you seen any good movies lately?
You're talking about books	Have you read any good books lately?
You're talking about food	Do you know any good restaurants around here?
You're talking about travel	Have you been on vacation recently?
You're talking about work	How's work going?
You're talking about the weekend	Did you do anything fun this weekend?
You're talking about the weather	It's been really hot/cold lately, hasn't it?

You're talking about the city

Do you like living here?

You're talking about the office

How long have you been working here?

You're talking about the team

How big is the team?

Questions to Start a Conversation

- Did you do anything interesting at the weekend?
- Did you have a good weekend?
- Did you have a busy day today?
- What do you do in your spare time?
- Do you have any plans for the evening?
- Do you have any plans for the weekend?
- Did you watch that game last night?
- Do you like sports?
- Do you follow any sports teams?
- Have you seen any good movies lately?
- What was the last movie you saw?
- Do you have any recommendations?
- Have you read any good books lately?
- What do you think about...? (recent positive news)

Phrase Bank

Greetings

Phrases to start small talk	Phrases to respond
How're you doing today?	Pretty good, thank you. How're you doing?
	Pretty well, thank you.
	Doing good. How are you?
	Doing well. How are you?
How's it going?	Fine/great, thanks. Having a good week. How're you doing?
How's your day going?	Great, thanks for asking. I'm very excited about the interview. And how's your day?
How's your day been so far?	So far, so good. I've been rather busy lately. And how's your day going?

Weather

Phrases to start small talk	Phrases to respond
How's the weather over there?	(Unfortunately), it's raining/snowing. What's the weather like in [location]?
What's the weather like in [location] today?	It's stopped raining/snowing, luckily.
I hear the weather's been bad in [location] recently.	It's quite hot today. It's normally much cooler in May.
Are you enjoying the weather today?	That's right. It's been raining for three days in a row. Does it often rain where you are?
	Yes, I love summer and just hope it lasts a bit longer. How about you?

Weekend

Phrases to start small talk	Phrases to respond
So, how was your weekend?	Oh, you know, it was nothing special. I just did some housework and met up with some friends. How was your weekend?
	It was a pretty quiet weekend. I can't say that I did anything special. How about your weekend?

Ending a Conversation

Phrases to start	Phrases to respond
It was nice talking to you.	You too. Have a nice day!
I'd better get going.	Sure, it was nice talking to you.
I should probably get going.	Same here. Good luck with the interview!
I think I should go now.	Nice talking to you. See you later!

Structure:

1. Acknowledge something positive ("It was nice talking to you")
2. Say you need to go ("I'd better get going")
3. Thank them or wish them well ("Have a nice day!")

Taboo Topics

- Religion
- Health
- Politics
- Salary
- Personal questions (family, age, relationships)
- Negative comments about previous employers
- Complaining

Don'ts

- Don't ask personal questions
- Don't talk about salary
- Don't be negative
- Don't complain about your previous job

- Don't talk about politics or religion
- Don't interrupt the interviewer
- Don't talk too much
- Don't be too quiet

Active Listening

Active listening means showing the other person that you are listening and paying attention to what they are saying.

When the interviewer is talking about something for more than 30 seconds, show that you are following along. Use these phrases:

- "Right"
- "I see"
- "Sure"
- "Uh-huh"

When you are speaking with the interviewer, try to keep eye contact and smile. It shows that you are interested and confident.

Tips:

- Keep eye contact
- Smile
- Don't interrupt while the interviewer is talking
- Pay attention to the other person
- Be a good listener

Preparation: Think of some comments and answers to typical small talk questions and practice them with colleagues/friends.

When You're Stuck

If you can't think of what to say, check the [Follow-Up Questions](#) guide for tips and examples.

Follow-Up Questions

Follow-up questions help keep the conversation going during small talk and show interest in the other person.

When to Use Follow-Up Questions

- When you don't understand something
- When you need more information
- When you want to keep the conversation going
- When you want to show interest

Closed vs Open-Ended Questions

Type	Description	Example
Closed	Can be answered with yes/no	Do you like movies?
Open-ended	Requires a longer answer	What types of movies do you enjoy?

Tip: Use open-ended questions when you want more information. Use closed questions when you want to confirm something.

Questions for the Interviewer

Question	Notes
Do you still have to interview a lot of candidates?	
Do you have to make the decision soon?	
Do you live far away from the office?	
What is the weather like in your city?	
Which part of the city do you live in?	
How long have you been living there?	
Did you study at a university here?	
Have you ever been to other countries?	

Small Talk Topics

Countries

Question	Notes
Have you been to other countries?	
Which countries have you visited?	
How many times have you been there?	

Local Area

Question	Notes
Which part of the city do you live in?	
How long have you been living there?	
Did you study at a university here?	

Weather

Question	Notes
What is the weather like in your city?	
How's the weather today?	

Shopping

Question	Notes
Where did you buy that dress?	
I'd like to buy one for my friend. She lives in...	

Entertainment

Question	Notes
Do you have any plans for the weekend?	
Do you have any plans for the evening?	
Have you seen any good movies lately?	
What types of movies do you enjoy?	
Can you recommend any good films?	
Have you read any good books lately?	
Do you have any recommendations?	
Where do you usually go on vacation?	

Tips

- Show interest in the other person
- Keep the conversation going
- Be a good listener
- Use follow-up questions naturally
- Ask both closed and open-ended questions

Clarifying Questions

If you didn't understand something, ask for clarification:

- "Sorry, do you mean...?"
- "Are you saying that...?"
- "Could you explain that again?"
- "What do you mean by...?"

When You're Stuck

If you are nervous and cannot find anything to say, try this: think of the last thing you did before the interview. Think of something small that you did and add a positive comment to it.

Examples

Situation: Ate some cereal **Comment:** It was delicious. **Question:** Do you like cereal?

Situation: Watched some TV **Comment:** There were some funny shows. **Question:** Do you watch a lot of TV?

Situation: Got dressed **Comment:** I took a long time to get dressed. **Question:** Do you normally dress up for an interview?

Tips for When You're Stuck

- Think of something you did before the interview
- Make a comment about it
- Turn the comment into a question

Example:

1. You watched TV at the weekend
2. You can say: "I watched a movie at the weekend, it was great."
3. Then you can ask: "Do you like movies? Do you have any recommendations?"

Tell Me About Yourself

This is a common question that you should expect at the beginning of every interview.

Why Interviewers Ask This

- Breaks the ice and transitions from small talk into the actual interview
- Helps the interviewer plan follow-up questions based on what you mention
- Shows how well prepared you are for the interview

Tips

- Focus on the needs of the job position — not hobbies or passions
- Read the job description and choose information relevant to the position
- Don't include too much detail — your self-presentation shouldn't be longer than **2 minutes**
- Don't repeat all the facts from your resume — you'll have a chance to elaborate later
- Support your skills with examples and facts
- Don't use generic phrases like "I'm a hard worker" or "I'm a people person"

Structure (2 Magic Minutes)

Your self-presentation should include:

1. **Current position** — What are you doing now?
2. **Education** — Where did you study?
3. **Relevant experience** — What projects have you worked on?
4. **Achievements** — What are you proud of?
5. **Why this position** — Why are you interested in this job?

1. Who you are professionally

Your current position, most important responsibilities, and experience relevant to the position. If you have no or very little work experience, say a few words about your educational background. A couple of sentences is enough.

2. Why you are qualified

Say how your technical and soft skills fit the position and support them with examples. Mention a few major accomplishments that would interest the interviewer.

3. Why you are here

Show you're excited about the opportunity and stress your interest in the position. Be light, enthusiastic, and positive to leave a strong first impression.

Don't Use These Answers

Avoid generic answers that don't show anything about you:

- "I'm a hard worker."
- "I'm a people person."
- "I'm a team player."
- "I'm a good communicator."
- "I'm a quick learner."
- "I'm a problem solver."
- "I'm a self-starter."

These answers are clichés. They don't prove anything about your skills or experience. Instead, support your answer with examples from your life.

Examples

Bad answer

I am a computer science graduate. I like computers. I like to spend time with my family and friends. I am a good person.

Why it's bad:

- Focuses on personal life, not professional skills
- Doesn't mention any relevant experience
- Doesn't show why you're qualified for the position

Good answer

I studied at Instituto Tecnológico de Ciudad Guzmán and graduated on october 2023 with a degree in computer science.
I've worked in some projects as a front-end developer using technologies like JavaScript, ReactJS, NodeJS, etc.

Why it's good:

- Focuses on education and work history

- Mentions relevant technologies
- Shows relevant experience

Tips for Your Answer

1. **Who you are professionally:** Your current position, most important responsibilities, and experience relevant to the position
2. **Why you are qualified:** Say how your technical and soft skills fit the position and support them with examples
3. **Why you are here:** Show you're excited about the opportunity and stress your interest in the position

How to Structure Your Answer

When answering "Tell me about yourself", think about:

- **Your current role:** What are you doing now?
- **Your background:** What is your education and experience?
- **Your skills:** What can you do?
- **Your goals:** What do you want to do?

Example Structure

Part 1: Who you are professionally

I am a frontend developer with 2 years of experience working with React and JavaScript.

Part 2: Why you are qualified

I have worked on several projects where I built responsive web applications. For example, I developed a dashboard that helped my team track project progress.

Part 3: Why you are here

I am excited about this opportunity because I want to work on innovative projects and grow as a developer.

Common Mistakes

- Talking about personal life instead of professional experience
- Not mentioning relevant skills or experience
- Being too generic or vague

- Talking too long (more than 2 minutes)
- Not connecting your answer to the position

Practice

Write down your own answer using the structure above. Practice saying it out loud. Make sure it sounds natural and confident.

Step 1: Write down your current role and experience **Step 2:** Write down your relevant skills and accomplishments **Step 3:** Write down why you want this position **Step 4:** Practice saying it out loud **Step 5:** Time yourself (aim for 2 minutes or less)

Self-Presentation Template

Use this template to structure your answer:

Hi, my name is [Your Name]. I am a [Your Role] with [X years] of experience in [Your Field].

Currently, I work at [Company] where I [Your Responsibilities]. Before that, I [Previous Experience].

I studied [Your Education] at [University]. During my studies, I [Academic Achievements].

I am proud of [Your Achievement]. For example, [Specific Example].

I am interested in this position because [Why This Position]. I believe my skills in [Your Skills] would be a great fit for your team.

Talking About Past Projects

Be ready to talk about your past project(s) to anyone with a limited technical background in 60 seconds.

What was the project goal?

- On my previous project we had to + V.
- On my previous project we were tasked with + noun/V-ing.
- I was working on a project with a client, and they wanted to + V.

What specifically did you do?

- I was responsible for + noun/V-ing.
- I was in charge of + noun/V-ing.
- I worked very closely with + N.

What challenges did you face?

- I ran into a problem with + noun/V-ing.
- We had a minor issue with...
- I faced a dilemma about whether to + V or not.

What were your key achievements?

- The project allowed me to put my knowledge of... into practice.
- I gained a lot of valuable experience in + noun/V-ing.
- My participation in the project taught me about + noun/V-ing.
- I learnt that...
- I managed to + V.

Communication Strategies

When the interviewer asks a difficult question, use these strategies to avoid awkward pauses and buy time to think.

1. Ask to Repeat the Question

Don't be shy — it's not a big deal for the interviewer. Nobody expects you to have a native-like English level.

- "Could you please repeat the question?"
- "Sorry, I didn't catch that. Could you say it again?"
- "Sorry?"

Avoid saying "What?" — it sounds rude in formal situations.

2. Clarify That You Understand

Don't answer if you doubt whether you've understood correctly.

- "Sorry, do you mean (that)...?"
- "Let me just check if I understand you correctly. Do you mean...?"
- "Do you want me to speak about / explain...?"
- "Could you explain what you mean by...?"

Signaling Understanding

After clarification, say thank you to signal you're ready to answer:

- "I got it. Thank you!"
- "Ah, I see what you mean. Thanks for clarifying."
- "Now I understand. Thanks a lot."

3. Buy Thinking Time

Rephrase the question in your own words to buy time. Even if you can't answer immediately, don't keep silent — the interviewer may think something is wrong.

Phrases to buy time

- "Well, let me think about that for a moment."
- "I'd like to give that some thought."

When you don't have the answer

Offer at least a thought or perspective:

- "I'm not quite sure. But I think..."
- "Well, it's difficult to say exactly, but..."
- "I'm afraid I don't know exactly, but here's a thought."

4. Dealing with Difficult Questions

Sometimes the interviewer can ask you a really difficult question. Here are some strategies:

What You Can Do

- Say that you need some time to think
- Clarify that you understand the question if necessary
- Ask the interviewer to repeat the question
- Thank the interviewer for the question
- Say that you'll think about it and give your answer at the end of the interview

What You Should Avoid

- Admit that you don't know the answer and ask for the next question (shows lack of preparation)
- Keep silent for a few minutes thinking about the answer (awkward, interviewer may think something is wrong)

5. Dealing with Technical Issues

For virtual interviews, be prepared to handle technical problems:

- "Sorry, you're on mute."
- "Can you please unmute yourself?"
- "Sorry, you're breaking up."
- "The Internet connection is spotty."
- "Can you hear me well?"
- "Sorry, the connection is not stable. I'll call you back in a minute."
- "I guess it's an issue on your end."

Examples

Conversation 1: Microphone issue

Interviewer: Hello Catherine, nice to meet you. How is the week going so far?

Candidate: ...

Interviewer: It seems you're on mute. Can you please check your microphone and unmute yourself?

Candidate: Oh, can you hear me now? I'm so sorry about that. It's my first interview on Skype and I don't know how it works.

Conversation 2: Bad connection

Interviewer: So what we really wanted ... about you is ...

Candidate: Sorry, I didn't catch that. Could you say it again?

Interviewer: Sure, I was saying that ... wanted to ...

Candidate: Sorry, you're breaking up. The Internet connection is really spotty here.

Interviewer: Sorry about that. Looks like we have an issue with the wi-fi connection in the office, let me call you back in a minute.

Conversation 3: Echo issue

Interviewer: Now could you please tell me more about... Oh, I'm sorry, I keep hearing my own voice. Can you hear me well?

Candidate: Yes, I can hear you loud and clear.

Interviewer: I guess it's an issue on your end then. Are you using a headset?

Candidate: No, I'm afraid I don't have one.

Interviewer: Ok, got it. In this case, just lower the volume a little bit.

Tips

- Don't keep silent — the interviewer may think something is wrong
- Use these strategies to buy time to think
- Practice saying these phrases out loud
- Be natural and confident

Summary

Situation	Strategy	Example
Didn't hear	Ask to repeat	"Could you please repeat the question?"
Didn't understand	Clarify	"Sorry, do you mean...?"
Need time to think	Buy time	"Well, let me think about that for a moment."
Don't know the answer	Offer a thought	"I'm not quite sure. But I think..."
Technical issues	Handle politely	"Sorry, the connection is not stable. I'll call you back in a minute."

Practice

Write down your own answers using these strategies. Practice saying them out loud. Make sure they sound natural and confident.

Tips for Communication

- Speak slowly and clearly
- Don't rush your answers
- Use simple words
- Keep your answers concise
- Be confident but not arrogant
- Use signal words to structure your answers (First, Second, Finally, However, etc.)
- Don't use slang or informal language

PREP Framework

A framework for answering interview questions effectively. A good answer should be informative, based on reason, and easy to follow.

What is PREP?

Letter	Meaning	Description
P	Point	State your main point or opinion
R	Reason	Give a reason for your opinion
E	Example	Provide a personal example to prove your point
P	Point	Repeat your main idea to leave a clear message

Example: "Are you a team player?"

Bad answer (not informative)

"Yes, I think so. Teams are important. Team-members can help one another and do tasks together."

General statement, doesn't prove personal skills.

Good answer (PREP)

Point: Yes, I think I'm a good team-player.

Reason: Because I am always ready to help my team members with their tasks.

Example: For example, last week I stayed late at work to prepare my colleague for her technical assessment.

Point: On the whole, I try to support other people and help them do their best.

Incomplete Answers

You can skip parts of PREP if needed, but the more complete, the better.

Point + Reason (no Example or final Point)

"Yes, I think so, because I am outgoing, friendly, and have good communication skills."

Good, but no personal story to back it up.

Point + Example (no Reason or final Point)

"I think I'm a good team-player. For example, when there was a conflict on the team, I helped the colleagues to understand one another's point of view and solve the problem."

Personal story helps, but the reason is not stated.

When to Use PREP

- When you want to provide more information
- When you want to sound convincing and well-reasoned
- For behavioral questions ("Tell me about a time when...")
- For opinion questions ("Do you think...?")

How to Practice PREP

1. Think of a question you might be asked
2. Write down your Point
3. Write down your Reason
4. Write down your Example
5. Write down your final Point
6. Practice saying it out loud

Linking Words

Use these phrases to connect your ideas:

PREP Part	Linking Words
Point	I think I'd say / I would say
Reason	Because / As
Example	For example / For instance
Point	That's why / Therefore

Practice Questions

Answer these questions using the PREP framework:

1. What are your core skills/strengths?
2. In your opinion, what makes a project successful?

More Examples

"Why should we hire you?"

Point: You should hire me for several reasons.

Reason: The first reason is because I love what I do. I am passionate about this type of work.

Example: For example, in my last project, I spent extra time learning a new technology to make the application better.

Point: I believe my passion and skills would be a great fit for your team.

"What is your greatest strength?"

Point: I would say my greatest strength is communication.

Reason: I find that this is very important because it helps us to build relationships, share ideas, thoughts or experiences with our clients or team members.

Example: For example, in my last project, I helped the team understand a complex problem by explaining it in simple terms.

Point: I believe good communication is key to success in any team.

Contrasting and Comparing

NB! = Nota Bene (latín para "bien nota" o "presta atención"). Se usa para resaltar información importante.

How to answer questions about advantages and disadvantages of tools or solutions. Instead of just naming one option, compare alternatives to show critical thinking.

Why It Matters

When an interviewer asks about the best tool for a task, naming one option isn't enough. If you don't consider alternatives, you miss the chance to demonstrate your reasoning ability.

How to Structure the Answer

1. Mention two or more options
2. Talk about what they have in common
3. Contrast the differences (pros and cons)
4. Give a recommendation

Example: "What's the best tool for developing a web application?"

I would probably choose between tool1 and tool2. Both tool1 and tool2 have speedy user interface and great efficiency.

Compared with tool1, tool2 is a bit less complicated, which is great if you have a lot of junior developers on the project.

However, tool1 is updated on a regular basis, whereas support for tool2 stopped some time ago.

On the whole, I would recommend using tool1, but tool2 is just as reliable and can be a second option to consider for a project.

Signal Words

These words help structure comparisons and contrasts:

Purpose	Words
Comparing	"Both...", "Similarly", "Just like", "Also"
Contrasting	"However", "Compared with", "Whereas", "On the other hand", "In contrast"
Concluding	"On the whole", "Overall", "In conclusion"

Tips

- Always offer more than one option
- Mention pros and cons of each solution
- Use signal words to make the comparison clear
- Conclude with a recommendation

Describing Similarities

Both ... and ...

- Both tool 1 and tool 2 have speedy interface.

NB! The verb should be in the **plural form**.

(Just) as + adjective/adverb + as

- Tool 2 is just as reliable as tool 1.
- The new app is just as useful as the old one.

NB! The word "just" is used for emphasis and can be omitted.

(Just) like

- Just like Quizlet, Memrise allows you to create vocabulary flashcards.

NB! "Like" is a preposition and is used before nouns. It means exactly the same. The word "just" is used for emphasis and can be omitted.

Describing Differences

The main difference between ... and ... is

- The main difference between tool 1 and tool 2 is the frequency of updates.

Unlike

- Unlike windowed operating systems, smartphones generally present apps full-screen.

NB! "Unlike" is a preposition and is used before nouns. It means "different from".

Compared to/with

- New version is unusable compared with the older version.

NB! "Compared to/with" is used before nouns and noun phrases.

However

- We thought the figures were correct. However, we have now discovered some errors.

NB! "However" is used to introduce a statement that contrasts with something that has just been said.

When to Compare

- When asked about the best tool for a task
- When asked about advantages and disadvantages
- When asked to choose between options
- When asked about your experience with different technologies

STAR Framework

A framework for answering questions about your competencies and past experiences. The interviewer will ask questions where you need to give examples from your life to demonstrate how you used a particular skill or knowledge.

What is STAR?

Letter	Meaning	Description
S	Situation	Describe where and when your story took place
T	Task	Explain the task you had to complete and any challenges
A	Action	Describe the specific actions YOU took (use "I", not "we")
R	Result	Describe the positive effect of your actions

Example: "What's your biggest achievement?"

Situation

On my last project I was working in a team of six engineers and we were developing a new feature for our core product. At first, we thought we would complete the project on time, but then two team members, including our team leader, fell seriously ill.

Task

We had to meet the original deadline, which was in a few days' time and we didn't have a team leader. So, the whole team was under serious pressure.

Action

I was pretty confident in my programming skills, so I volunteered as a team leader. Due to my technical analysis skills, I managed to find a few mistakes in the initial coding and fixing them allowed the project to move faster. I also motivated my team to work overtime for a couple of days to fix all the problems before the

release. When I told the customer about this, they promised a small bonus for the team.

Result

As a result, the project was successfully finished on time. The customer was extremely satisfied with the product and the team was happy to receive the extra bonus. It was a challenging experience, but I really enjoyed the feeling of achievement. I also learnt a lot about initiative and improved my communication skills.

Tips

- Use "I" rather than "we" in the Action part — this is your time to demonstrate your skills
- Don't reveal sensitive data about previous or current projects and customers
- Speak about a specific situation, not general experiences
- Emphasize YOUR role in the story
- Describe how you developed from that experience

Linkers

Sequencing

- First, ...
- Then, ...
- Next, ...
- After that, ...
- In the end, ...
- Finally, ...

Adding

- Also, ...
- Besides, ...
- In addition, ...
- Moreover, ...

Introducing Results

- So, ...

- As a result, ...

Bonus Phrases

Situation

- Way back in 2015...
- When I was working on the XYZ project...
- At the beginning of last year...
- On my previous project...
- When I was involved in...
- We ran into the problem...
- We faced some issues with...

Task

- The task was to...
- We/I had to...
- We/I needed to...
- I was asked to...
- The client wanted us to...

Action

- I came up with the idea...
- I implemented...
- I identified...
- I supported...
- I investigated...
- I spent [three months] evaluating the issue...
- I set up...
- I kept my team informed of/about...
- I improved...
- I designed...
- I got promoted to...

Result

- I learnt a lot from the experience.
- It taught me...
- What I learnt is...

- I grew into the role of...
- ... was a huge success.

Common STAR Questions

- What's your biggest achievement?
- Tell me about a time when...
- Can you describe a situation when...?
- Give an example of when you...
- Describe a challenge you faced and how you overcame it.

Questions to the Interviewer

An interview should be two-sided. Asking relevant questions demonstrates interest, initiative, and strategic understanding of the position. Having no questions sends the message that you haven't given the interview enough thought.

When to Ask

During the Interview

Ask clarifying questions to get more details about the task. This shows critical thinking and helps you provide a better answer.

Example questions:

- What features do you want to implement immediately? And what features can wait until later in the project?
- How many people will use the system every day, both customers and admin staff?
- What are the deadlines for the development and implementation?

Tips:

- Ask both closed and open-ended questions for more information
- Instead of "Do you expect this kind of information to be in there?" ask "What do you expect to see when you...?"
- If you didn't understand the answer, ask for clarification: "Sorry, do you mean...?" or "Are you saying that...?"

At the End of the Interview

When the interviewer asks "Do you have any questions?", this is your chance to show you've done your research.

Preparation:

- Research the company, customer, project, and position
- Check who your interviewer will be
- Prepare at least three questions
- Don't ask questions already answered during the interview
- Avoid questions clearly answered on the website or provided materials

Types of Questions

Clarifying Questions

Find out the details in order to offer a better solution:

- What features do you want to implement immediately?
- How many people will use the system every day, both customers and admin staff?
- What are the deadlines for the development and implementation?

Project Questions

When there's little or no information about the project:

- How much time do we have to complete this project?
- What is the main goal of the project?
- What technologies are used on the project?
- Do you follow a specific methodology?
- What software development methodology do you use?
- Are there any issues on the project that need to be addressed immediately?

Position Questions

- What support do you offer to newcomers?
- How much time do you give a newcomer to integrate into the team? / How much time do you allow/provide for onboarding?
- What are your expectations of the candidate?
- How do you measure the success of a person in this position? / What are the KPIs for this position? (KPIs = Key Performance Indicators)

Team Questions

- Can you tell me about the team I will work with?
- Who will I work most closely with?
- How big is the team?
- Is the team globally distributed?
- Do you work across different time zones?

Possible Question Topics

Topic	Example Questions
The Project	How much time do we have to complete this project? What software development methodology do you use? Are there any issues on the project that need to be addressed immediately?
The Position	How much time do you give a newcomer to integrate into the team? What are your expectations of the candidate? How do you measure the success of a person in this position?
The Team	Can you tell me about the team I will work with? Is the team globally distributed? Do you work across different time zones?

Tips

- Be proactive, but not overconfident
- Avoid interrupting the interviewer
- Show you have done your research
- Ask at the appropriate moment
- Prepare at least three questions
- Don't ask questions already answered during the interview

Reacting to the Interviewer's Answers

After the interviewer answers your questions, acknowledge their response:

- "Thank you for your answer."
- "Thanks, that's good to know."
- "OK I see, thank you."

Example Questions

About the Project

- How much time do we have to complete this project?
- What software development methodology do you use?
- Are there any issues on the project that need to be addressed immediately?
- What are the most important features for the first release?

About the Position

- How much time do you give a newcomer to integrate into the team?
- What are your expectations of the candidate?

- How do you measure the success of a person in this position?
- What are the main challenges of this position?

About the Team

- Can you tell me about the team I will work with?
- Is the team globally distributed?
- Do you work across different time zones?
- How big is the team?

Question Formation

How to form questions correctly in English for interviews.

Don't Do This

Don't ask questions by just raising your intonation or adding "yes/no" at the end:

- ❌ "The team globally distributed, yes?"
- ❌ "You work across different time zones, not?"

These are not real questions. In English, you need to use **inversion** (auxiliary verb before the subject).

Yes/No Questions

Start with an auxiliary or modal verb, then add the rest of the sentence.

Question	Auxiliary/Modal	Subject	Main Verb
Is the team globally distributed?	is	the team	distributed
Do you work across different time zones?	do	you	work
Do you follow a specific methodology?	do	you	follow
Can you tell me about the team I will work with?	can	you	tell

Wh- Questions

Begin with a question word (who, what, where, why, when, whose, which, how).

Structure: Question word + auxiliary verb + subject + main verb + extra info

Remember this phrase: "How do you do?"

Question Word	Auxiliary	Subject	Main Verb
How	do	you	do?
Where	is	the team	based?
What	does	a typical support request	look like?
What	do	you	use?
Who	will	I	work with?
How	do	you	measure?

Examples

- What software development methodology do you use?
- Who will I work most closely with?
- How do you measure the success of a person in this position?
- Where is the team based?
- What does a typical support request look like?

Tips

- Always use inversion (verb before subject)
- Use auxiliary verbs: do, does, is, are, can, will, etc.
- Start with the question word for Wh- questions
- Practice the structure: "How do you do?"

Interview Phrase Bank

Phrases to describe your professional background during an interview.

Role and Responsibilities

- I'm a/an [your position].
- I focus primarily on + noun/V-ing.
- I'm also responsible for + noun/V-ing.

Work Experience

- I've been in the IT industry for [number of years/months].
- I did an internship at [name of the company].
- I started as a/an [position].

Educational Background

- I'm a senior at [university/college name] studying [the main subject you study].
- I took a course in...
- I graduated from [university/college name].

Skills and Knowledge

- I'm (pretty) good at + noun/V-ing.
- I have good [problem solving, communication, etc.] skills.
- I have (quite) a good knowledge of + noun/V-ing.
- I'm comfortable with + noun/V-ing.

Accomplishments

- I've gained a lot of valuable experience in + noun/V-ing.
- I've managed to get a (pretty) good understanding of + noun/V-ing.

About the Position

- I'm really excited about the opportunity to work on this project.
- I think my education and experience make me a good fit for this position.
- I think the combination of my skills and experience could be a good addition to your team.

Common Interview Questions

Questions the Interviewer Might Ask You

1. Tell me a little bit about yourself

Tip: Focus on education and work history.

Hi, nice to meet you. My name is Alan González, and I'm a software developer based in Guadalajara, Mexico. I have more than three years of experience working in the IT industry. I enjoy building user interfaces with React.js, and I'm currently looking for a remote frontend developer position where I can use my skills and continue growing as a developer.

2. Can you tell me how you heard about this position?

I found this position on LinkedIn. After reviewing the job description and qualifications, I felt that my skills and experience were a strong match for the role.

3. What attracted you to our company?

What attracted me to your company is your focus on building AI-powered solutions. I believe artificial intelligence is a powerful technology that helps businesses automate tasks, save time, and improve efficiency. I'm also excited about the opportunity to work with innovative technologies and continue developing my skills while contributing to meaningful projects.

4. What would you say is your greatest strength?

I would say my greatest strength is problem-solving. I enjoy analyzing technical problems, researching different solutions, and finding the most efficient one. I also learn quickly, which has helped me work with both modern and legacy technologies.

5. What is your greatest weakness?

My biggest weakness is public speaking. It's something I've been actively working on by participating more in meetings whenever I have the opportunity. I've improved a lot, but I know there's still room to grow.

6. Where do you see yourself in 5 years?

In five years, I see myself working as a Senior Full Stack Developer, leading projects, mentoring junior developers, and continuing to learn new technologies.

7. Why are you interested in working for this company?

I'm interested in working for your company because I believe my skills and experience align well with this role. I also like that your company focuses on innovative technologies, and I see it as a place where I can continue growing while contributing to meaningful projects.

8. Tell me about your education.

I studied Computer Systems Engineering at Instituto Tecnológico de Ciudad Guzmán. In addition, I've completed several courses in web development across different learning platforms, mainly focused on frontend development. I also took backend development courses, which helped me become a full-stack developer. Throughout my career, I've gained experience working with technologies such as React.js and Node.js.

9. Why have you chosen this particular field?

I've been passionate about technology since I was a child. What I enjoy the most is creating applications that people can interact with. That's why I decided to specialize in frontend development, where I can combine problem-solving with creating intuitive and user-friendly interfaces.

10. In a job, what interests you most?

I am interested in growth and learning. I've always liked to keep myself updated. I am always learning about new technology trends. Therefore, I try to learn as much as I can from my clients or teammates.

11. How do others describe you?

Other people would describe me as loyal, trustworthy, responsible, empathetic, respectful, and someone they can always call whenever they need help or advice. Also, they would describe me as honest, organized and detail-oriented.

12. Why should we hire you?

You should hire me because I already have experience building React applications in production environments. I'm a quick learner, I enjoy solving technical challenges, and I'm always looking for ways to improve both the code and the user experience.

13. How do you think you will fit into this operation?

I find my profile fits very well in this position because I have some experience working with the technologies that are requested in the job description.

14. What have you done to develop or change in the last few years?

I became a self-taught person. In the last few years, I took many courses about web development, and when I have an error I proceed to search for possible solutions from different sources.

17. Give an example of how you solved a problem in the past.

One example was when I joined Mega's IT team. I had to work with legacy technologies such as VB6, RPT, and RDLC reports. Since there wasn't much documentation available, I spent time analyzing the existing codebase, reading old documentation, and testing different solutions. By doing that, I was able to understand the system and successfully implement new features and bug fixes. That experience taught me how to solve problems independently, even when resources are limited.

18. What do you consider your best accomplishment in your last job?

One of my biggest accomplishments was becoming productive with legacy technologies in a short period of time. When I joined the team, I had no experience with VB6 or RDLC reports, but I quickly learned how the system worked and started contributing to new features and bug fixes. That experience helped me become more adaptable and confident when working with unfamiliar technologies.

19. If you were hired, what ideas/talents could you contribute to the position or our company?

I believe I could contribute by building clean, maintainable, and user-friendly applications. I enjoy solving technical problems, learning new technologies, and continuously improving the user experience. I also like collaborating with my teammates, sharing ideas, and always looking for ways to improve both the product and the development process.

20. Give an example where you showed leadership and initiative.

One example was during the development of my Point of Sale system. While implementing the barcode scanner, I realized that the same solution didn't work well on both Android and iOS. Instead of accepting the limitation, I researched different alternatives, evaluated several libraries, and implemented separate solutions for each platform. Taking the initiative to investigate and solve the problem resulted in a much better experience for users.

21. Give an example of when you were able to contribute to a team project.

During my time at Tata Consultancy Services, I worked closely with other developers to build and maintain React applications. I collaborated with backend developers to integrate REST APIs, participated in code reviews, and helped troubleshoot issues reported by the team. Good communication and teamwork allowed us to deliver new features on time while maintaining code quality.

22. Do you have any questions for me?

Sure. I have a few.

23. What are your aspirations?

One of my greatest aspirations is to become a highly skilled software developer. I would like to contribute for creating software solutions that make people's lives easier and more efficient.

24. What projects have you worked on?

Mainly I focused on developing user interfaces applyin

During my last semester at university, I worked as frontend developer developing the client side of a web scrapping application, where I used technologies like HTML, CSS, JavaScript and ReactJS.

25. What programming languages do you know?

I've heard of many. But the ones that I use the most are JavaScript and Java.

26. Are you available to join?

Yes, I am available for a full-time position and can start immediately. I am excited about the opportunity to join.

27. What do you know about our company?

Don't answer with "not much" or "I haven't looked into it yet". This shows you don't care.

Bad answer:

Um... not much, actually.

Better answer:

Yes, it's a big company. They have offices all over the world. They have a lot of interesting projects. I am really interested in this position.

Tips:

- Do your research before the interview
- Check the company website

- Mention something specific about the company

28. What is your dream job?

Don't say "I don't have a dream job". This shows you don't care about your career.

Bad answer:

Um... I don't have a dream job, actually.

Better answer:

My dream job is to work as a software developer in a company where I can use my skills and experience to help the company grow. I would like to work in a company where I can learn new things and grow as a person.

Tips:

- Show you care about your career
- Mention something specific about the position
- Show you want to grow

29. Why are you interested in working for a US company?

I'm interested in working for a US company because I want to work on challenging projects, collaborate with talented people, and continue improving my technical and English skills. I also enjoy working in international environments where I can learn from different perspectives.

30. What are your biggest strengths as a frontend developer?

I think my biggest strengths are building clean and responsive user interfaces with React, writing maintainable code, solving problems efficiently, and always being willing to learn new technologies. I'm also a responsible team player, and I enjoy collaborating with others to deliver high-quality software.

31. Tell me about a challenging project you worked on.

I remember when I joined Mega's IT team. I had to learn how to work with legacy technologies such as VB6, RPT, and RDLC reports. At the beginning, it was quite challenging because there wasn't much information available online. Those technologies hadn't been updated in many years, so I had to spend hours reading

old documentation, analyzing the existing system, and figuring out how everything worked. That experience taught me how to learn independently and solve problems even when documentation is limited.

32. Can you describe a React project you're proud of?

One of the projects I'm most proud of is a point-of-sale system I built for a pharmacy. It allows users to scan products using their phone's camera, register sales, and generate reports, all from a single device.

One of the biggest challenges was implementing the barcode scanner. I discovered that the same library didn't perform well on both Android and iOS, so I evaluated different options and ended up using one library for Android and another for iOS. This solution provided a much better user experience on both platforms.

As a result, the pharmacy staff were able to process sales more efficiently without needing dedicated barcode scanner hardware, which reduced costs and simplified their workflow.

Tips:

- **Project:** ¿Qué desarrollaste?
- **Role:** ¿Cuál fue tu responsabilidad?
- **Challenge:** ¿Qué problema resolviste?
- **Solution:** ¿Cómo lo resolviste?
- **Impact:** ¿Qué beneficio obtuvo el cliente?

33. What would you do if a React application became slow?

If a React application became slow after adding a new feature, the first thing I would do is identify where the problem is coming from. I would use React Developer Tools and the browser's Performance tab to check for unnecessary re-renders or expensive operations.

Then, I would review the new code to see if there are components rendering too often, large API requests, or inefficient state updates. If necessary, I would optimize the application by using `React.memo`, `useMemo`, or `useCallback` to reduce unnecessary re-renders. I would also make sure that API calls are optimized and that only the required data is being loaded.

Finally, I would test the application again to verify that the changes improved performance without affecting the user experience.

34. How do you know when a component is re-rendering too many times?

I usually use React Developer Tools to inspect component renders. If I notice that a component re-renders even when its props or state haven't changed, I investigate the cause and optimize it if necessary.

35. What are your availability hours?

I'm available from 9 AM to 6 PM EST. I'm flexible and can adjust my schedule if needed.

31. Are you able to work in US time zones?

Yes, I'm able to work in US time zones. I'm used to working remotely and adjusting my schedule to match the team's hours.

36. Can you work flexible hours?

Yes, I can work flexible hours. I understand that sometimes we need to adjust our schedule to meet deadlines or attend meetings.

27. I'm a people person

"I'm a people person" is a common answer, but it's a cliché. Instead of just saying it, support your answer with reasons and examples.

Bad answer:

"Yes, I'm a people person."

Better answer:

I enjoy talking to people. For example, last week I spent some time talking to a colleague who was feeling upset about a situation at work. It was nice to get to know them better. I like talking to people and helping them feel better.

Why it works:

- Point: I enjoy talking to people
- Reason: (implied - because I like helping)

- Example: Spent time talking to a colleague who was upset
- Point: I like talking to people and helping them feel better

Questions to Ask the Interviewer

Work Schedule

1. Could you tell me more about the working hours for this position?

Could you tell me more about the working hours for this position?

2. What time does the workday usually start and end?

What time does the workday usually start and end?

3. Which time zone does the team work in?

Which time zone does the team work in?

4. Would I be expected to work in the company's time zone?

Would I be expected to work in the company's time zone?

General Questions

- What are the responsibilities and accountabilities of this position?
- How well is the position defined?
- Can its duties be expanded?
- Please describe an average day on this job.
- What are the key challenges or problems of this position?
- How would you describe the ideal candidate?
- What are the employer's short- and long-range objectives?
- What are some outside influences that affect company growth?
- Where does the company excel? What are its limitations?
- When and how will I be evaluated?
- What are the performance standards?

- With whom would I be working?
- Who would be my supervisor?
- Who would I supervise?
- What is the department's environment like?
- When will you make the hiring decision?
- May I call you for the decision?